

Spiritual Formation Four Connects

Fellowship of the Heart
July 2025



Overview

- Spiritual Formation definition/discussion
 - Individual
 - Collective
- 4 Connects Process
 - Connecting with yourself
 - Connecting with others
 - Connecting with God
 - Connecting with mission
- Ecology check



Some Grounding Scripture (ESV)

- Rom 12:2 “2 Do not be conformed to this world, **but be transformed** by the renewal of your mind, that by testing **you may discern what is the will of God**, what is good and acceptable and perfect.
- Eph 4:13 “ ...until we all attain to the unity of the faith and of the knowledge of the Son of God, to **mature** manhood, to the measure of the stature of the fullness of Christ...”
- Heb 5:14 “...but solid food is for the **mature**, for those who have their powers of discernment trained by constant practice to distinguish good from evil.”
- Heb 6:1 “...and go on to **maturity**...”

And Some More - Sanctification

- 2 Thes 2:13 “... because God chose you as the first fruits to be saved, through **sanctification** by the Spirit and belief in the truth.”
- 1 Thes 4:3: “For this is the will of God, your **sanctification**: that you abstain from sexual immorality”
- Ex 31:13: “...for this is a sign between me and you throughout your generations, that you may know that I, the Lord, **sanctify** you.”
- Jn 17:17: “**Sanctify** them in the truth; your word is truth.”
- 1 Thes 5:23: “Now may the God of peace himself **sanctify** you completely, and may your whole spirit and soul and body be kept blameless at the coming of our Lord Jesus Christ.”

Spiritual Formation In Community

- Eph 4:15-16 “Rather, speaking the truth in love, we are to **grow up** in every way into him who is the head, into Christ, 16 from whom the whole body, joined and held together by every joint with which it is equipped, when each part is working properly, **makes the body grow** so that it builds itself up in love.
- The Philippian Church’s first members were radically socially different.



4 Connects Process

- Connect with yourself
- Connect with others
- Connect with God
- Connect with mission





Overview of 4 C's Processes

- We use unusual tools for unusual results
 - Start with Scripture
 - Include imagery and parabel for heart language
 - Individual process then group process/discussion
- The focus is how to help you move into a deeper, more intimate relationship with the Father, with others, with yourself and your mission
 - Called spiritual formation
 - Also called sanctification



Connecting to Self



Are you ever surprised by what you do, or what comes out of your mouth?

Heart Scripture - Luke 6 (NET)

- 43** “For no good tree bears bad fruit, nor again does a bad tree bear good fruit,
44 for each tree is known by its own fruit. For figs are not gathered from thorns, nor are grapes picked from brambles.
- 45** The good person out of the good treasury of his heart produces good, and the evil person out of his evil treasury produces evil, for his mouth speaks from what fills his heart.



Garden of the Heart

- Prepare to write, but set it aside to start
- Relaxation exercise to get present to the great “I Am”
- Garden of the Heart
 - Record what happens
 - Share it





Garden of the Heart

- Return and invite in Jesus
 - Record what happens
 - Share it
- What might be the impact for you going forward in your life?
- What is your takeaway from this session?
- What will you do or say different?

Connect with Others

- Do you have some people in your life you would like to have a deeper connection?
- Do some people just irritate you?



[Rock Polishing](#)



Connect with Others

- 1 John 4:20
 - If someone says, "I love God," and hates his brother, he is a liar; for the **one who does not love his brother whom he has seen, cannot love God whom he has not seen.**
- Matt 7:1-5
 - " Do not judge so that you will not be judged. 2 "For in the way you judge, you will be judged; and by your standard of measure, it will be measured to you. ...
 - 5 **"You hypocrite, first take the log out of your own eye, and then you will see clearly to take the speck out of your brother's eye."**



**The only one qualified to
throw a stone... didn't.**

@GOTV

Connect with Samaritans in Your Life

- Who in your life really irritates you?
 - Why?
 - In what way or how?
 - How often?
- Pick one situation/person to discuss in your group
 - Ask for their feedback and suggestions
 - What would you like to do next?

Some Follow-up

- Write down a date to take whatever action you have decided
- The irritation point is there for a reason – your sanctification – ignore at your peril
- Reflective listening discussion
- Four questions to use for important relationships
 - Understanding your impact on their heart

Four Questions

1. What has it been like to be around me?
2. What have been my messages to you?
3. How have I wounded you?
4. What do you want from me going forward?



Connect with God

- Why would you want to be more connected to God?
- What's the deal if you are not connected?
- What's at risk for you to be more connected to God?





Connect with God

- John 14:8-14
 - 8 Philip said to Him, "Lord, show us the Father, and it is enough for us." 9 Jesus said to him, "Have I been so long with you, and yet you have not come to know Me, Philip? He who has seen Me has seen the Father; how can you say, 'Show us the Father'? 10 "Do you not believe that I am in the Father, and the Father is in Me? The words that I say to you I do not speak on My own initiative, **but the Father abiding in Me does His works.** 11 "Believe Me that I am in the Father and the Father is in Me; otherwise believe because of the works themselves. 12 "Truly, truly, I say to you, **he who believes in Me, the works that I do, he will do also; and greater works than these he will do; because I go to the Father.** 13 " Whatever you ask in My name, that will I do, so that the Father may be glorified in the Son. 14 **"If you ask Me anything in My name, I will do it.**



Connect with God

1. A time when you felt connected to God
2. Find an anchor for that
3. A time when you felt disconnected from God
4. Seeing if there is a pattern between the two
5. Bringing the connected anchor into the disconnected place



1 Cor 6:17 But the one united with the Lord is one spirit with him.



Connect with God

- Close eyes, relax. Remember a time when you may have felt connected to God, when God was present in your life.
- What did it look, sound and/or feel like.
 - Write that down
 - Anchor before going on
 - Share in pairs
- Think of a time when it felt like God was not around, no connection
 - Relaxation process
 - Write that down
 - Share in pairs
- Can you see a pattern in the two representations? What might connect with God look like in general for you?
 - Write that down
 - Share in group
 - Check and re-anchor if necessary before moving on

Connect with God

- Go back to that disconnected place and see if you can bring in the connected look/sound/feeling
 - Share in group
 - Is there something blocking, or in the way?
 - Share in group
- Explore the downside to a deeper connection, what would happen to your relationships, work, life, etc.
 - Write that down
 - Share in pairs

Hearing God

Matt 13:3-23 3 And He spoke many things to them in parables, saying, "Behold, the sower went out to sow; 4 and as he sowed, **some seeds fell beside the road**, and the birds came and ate them up. 5 **"Others fell on the rocky places**, where they did not have much soil; and immediately they sprang up, because they had no depth of soil. 6 "But when the sun had risen, they were scorched; and because they had no root, they withered away. 7 **"Others fell among the thorns**, and the thorns came up and choked them out. 8 **"And others fell on the good soil** and yielded a crop, some a hundredfold, some sixty, and some thirty. 9 " He who has ears, let him hear."

And the disciples came and said to Him, "Why do You speak to them in parables?" 11 Jesus answered them, " To you it has been granted to know the mysteries of the kingdom of heaven, but to them it has not been granted. 12 " For whoever has, to him more shall be given, and he will have an abundance; but whoever does not have, even what he has shall be taken away from him. 13 "Therefore I speak to them in parables; because while seeing they do not see, and while hearing they do not hear, nor do they understand. 14 " In their case the prophecy of Isaiah is being fulfilled, which says,



Hearing God

'YOU WILL KEEP ON HEARING, BUT WILL NOT UNDERSTAND;
YOU WILL KEEP ON SEEING, BUT WILL NOT PERCEIVE;
15 FOR THE HEART OF THIS PEOPLE HAS BECOME DULL,
WITH THEIR EARS THEY SCARCELY HEAR,
AND THEY HAVE CLOSED THEIR EYES,
OTHERWISE THEY WOULD SEE WITH THEIR EYES,
HEAR WITH THEIR EARS,
AND UNDERSTAND WITH THEIR HEART AND RETURN,
AND I WOULD HEAL THEM.'



Hearing God

16 " But blessed are your eyes, because they see; and your ears, because they hear. 17 "For truly I say to you that many prophets and righteous men desired to see what you see, and did not see it, and to hear what you hear, and did not hear it.

18 " Hear then the parable of the sower . 19 "When anyone hears the word of the kingdom and does not understand it, **the evil one comes and snatches away what has been sown in his heart.** This is the one on whom seed was sown beside the road. 20 "The one on whom seed was sown on the rocky places, this is the man who hears the word and immediately receives it with joy; 21 yet he has no firm root in himself, but is only temporary, **and when affliction or persecution arises because of the word, immediately he falls away.** 22 "And the one on whom seed was sown among the thorns, this is the man who hears the word, and **the worry of the world and the deceitfulness of wealth choke the word, and it becomes unfruitful.** 23 "And the one on whom seed was sown on the good soil, this is the man who **hears the word and understands it; who indeed bears fruit and brings forth, some a hundredfold, some sixty, and some thirty.**" NASU



Hearing God – The How

- Remembrance of hearing God at some point in your life
 - Visual
 - Auditory
 - Kinesthetic
- Make it richer/fuller
- Anchor it



Hearing God – The How

- Remember a place where you felt the Lord was not speaking
 - Change with anchor
 - Invite in Jesus, give Him permission to do His thing
 - Share with group

Hearing God – What If?

- Reflections for group
 - Obedience to what you have heard, opens you up to hearing more
 - Is there something you heard and did not obey?
 - Image of optometrist, my story
 - How do you know something is from the Lord?
 - Some basic standards - aligns with Scripture, reason, witness of Spirit, peace, community, circumstances
 - Lines up with these things
 - What if He is always speaking to you
 - What does it feel like to be a white male?
 - What does a fish think about water?
 - What if I am “bathed” in the Father speaking all the time?
 - What’s at Risk for you to hear?



Connect with Mission

- Do you know the reason you, personally are on this earth?
- Do you know the “talents” you will be held accountable for?



[Finding Your Mission](#)



Connect with Mission - Your Talents

- Matt 25:14-30

- " For it is just like a man about to go on a journey, who called his own slaves and entrusted his possessions to them. 15 "To one he gave five talents, to another, two, and to another, one, each according to his own ability; and he went on his journey. 16 "Immediately the one who had received the five talents went and traded with them, and gained five more talents. 17 "In the same manner the one who had received the two talents gained two more. 18 "But he who received the one talent went away, and dug a hole in the ground and hid his master's money. 19 "Now after a long time the master of those slaves came and settled accounts with them. 20 "The one who had received the five talents came up and brought five more talents, saying, 'Master, you entrusted five talents to me. See, I have gained five more talents.' 21 "His master said to him, **'Well done, good and faithful slave. You were faithful with a few things, I will put you in charge of many things; enter into the joy of your master.'** 22 "Also the one who had received the two talents came up and said, 'Master, you entrusted two talents to me. See, I have gained two more talents.' 23 "His master said to him, 'Well done, good and faithful slave. You were faithful with a few things, I will put you in charge of many things; enter into the joy of your master.'

Connect with Mission

- 24 "And the one also who had received the one talent came up and said, 'Master, I knew you to be a hard man, reaping where you did not sow and gathering where you scattered no seed. **25'And I was afraid, and went away and hid your talent in the ground.** See, you have what is yours.'
- 26 "But his master answered and said to him, '**You wicked, lazy slave,** you knew that I reap where I did not sow and gather where I scattered no seed. 27 Then you ought to have put my money in the bank, and on my arrival I would have received my money back with interest. 28 Therefore take away the talent from him, and give it to the one who has the ten talents.'
- 29 " For to everyone who has, more shall be given, and he will have an abundance; but from the one who does not have, even what he does have shall be taken away. 30 "**Throw out the worthless slave into the outer darkness; in that place there will be weeping and gnashing of teeth.**



Connect with Mission

Step 1 Identify your shadow mission

Step 2 Recognize the gifts and talents in play

Step 3 Reverse to apply to the Kingdom of God

Shadow Mission

- Uses your gifts and talents to build yourself up
- Damages your connections with others
- Damages those around you
- Leaves a bad feeling in others

Shadow Mission

- Reflect on your shadow mission
- Write out whatever level of detail you need
 - What is it that happens when you “go there”
 - What triggers it
 - What environmental things cause that trigger
- Share whatever you wish with your partner

Report Out

- Partners report to the group whatever they have permission to say
- Share each others shadow mission

Connect with Mission

- Criteria for your God given mission
 - Lines up with Scripture
 - Brings the Kingdom of God in those around you, you will see it reflected back to you
 - Brings the Kingdom of God in you, your life
 - It will take you on a journey of deeper conversational intimacy with the Father.
 - It lights your heart up, it is breathtaking – it is too good to be true, you say, “I’d LOVE to do that!”
 - You say with Isaiah, “Here I am, send me.” (Isa 6:8)
 - It brings you alive

Gold Mission

- Reverse the shadow mission
- Write out what that looks like
- Share with partner
- Partners share with the group whatever they have permission to say
- What is your takeaway from this session?
- What will you do or say differently in the future?



Ecology Check



- How many times have you been to the mountaintop – but nothing changed back in the valley?
- Do you want something different?
- Luke 14:28-30 "For which one of you, when he wants to build a tower, does not first sit down and calculate the cost to see if he has enough to complete it? "Otherwise, when he has laid a foundation and is not able to finish, all who observe it begin to ridicule him, saying, 'This man began to build and was not able to finish.'

The Parable of the Sower

Mark 4 Again, he began to teach beside the sea. And a very large crowd gathered about him, so that he got into a boat and sat in it on the sea, and the whole crowd was beside the sea on the land.² And he was teaching them many things in parables, and in his teaching he said to them: **3** “Listen! Behold, a sower went out to sow. **4** And as he sowed, some seed fell along the path, and the birds came and devoured it. **5** Other seed fell on rocky ground, where it did not have much soil, and immediately it sprang up, since it had no depth of soil. **6** And when the sun rose, it was scorched, and since it had no root, it withered away. **7** Other seed fell among thorns, and the thorns grew up and choked it, and it yielded no grain. **8** And other seeds fell into good soil and produced grain, growing up and increasing and yielding thirtyfold and sixtyfold and a hundredfold.” **9** And he said, “He who has ears to hear, let him hear.”

Continued

10 And when he was alone, those around him with the twelve asked him about the parables. 11 And he said to them, "To you has been given the secret of the kingdom of God, but for those outside everything is in parables, 12 so that " 'they may indeed see but not perceive, and may indeed hear but not understand, lest they should turn and be forgiven.' "

13 And he said to them, "Do you not understand this parable? How then will you understand all the parables? 14 The sower sows the word. 15 And these are the ones along the path, where the word is sown: when they hear, Satan immediately comes and takes away the word that is sown in them. 16 And these are the ones sown on rocky ground: the ones who, when they hear the word, immediately receive it with joy. 17 And they have no root in themselves, but endure for a while; then, when tribulation or persecution arises on account of the word, immediately they fall away. 18 And others are the ones sown among thorns. They are those who hear the word, 19 but the cares of the world and the deceitfulness of riches and the desires for other things enter in and choke the word, and it proves unfruitful. 20 But those that were sown on the good soil are the ones who hear the word and accept it and bear fruit, thirtyfold and sixtyfold and a hundredfold."

Ecology Check

- Did something new show up for you in this series? Is it something that you want to live out in your day-to-day life?
 - Write that down as clear as you can.
 - Share in pairs
 - What's at risk for you to live in this place?
 - Share crab and lottery stories
 - <https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=OpBdpgC97HE>
 - With a volunteer
 - What will oppose this new behavior in your life?
 - What will help you live from this place?
 - “What's at risk?” process with a volunteer
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What Help Do You Want?

- Koinonia – Community Life
- Set goals and ask for help
 - SMART goals
 - 3x3x3 process
 - Now over to you

A Reflection : 1 Cor 3

10 According to the grace of God given to me, like a skilled master-builder, I laid a foundation, but someone else builds on it. And each one must be careful how he builds. 11 For no one can lay any foundation other than what is being laid, which is Jesus Christ. 12 If anyone builds on the foundation with gold, silver, precious stones, wood, hay, or straw, 13 each builder's work will be plainly seen, for the Day will make it clear, because it will be revealed by fire. And the fire will test what kind of work each has done. 14 If what someone has built survives, he will receive a reward. 15 If someone's work is burned up, he will suffer loss. He himself will be saved, but only as through fire.

What's Next?

- Offer to join a follow-up group
 - A Fellowship of the Heart

Invitation to Spiritual Formation in and of a Community

- Goal
- Plans
- Status
- The Invitation



An Invitation to Join a Community on Your Personal Journey

- Theosis is the goal
- Community is the context
- Loving God and neighbor is the expression



Starting a “Fellowship of the Heart”

- Male and female community
 - Focus collective energy on spiritual formation
 - Test bed for collective processes
 - Offering personal, useful impact each time for participants
- Individual and collective spiritual formation processes
 - Extend to our kids and others
- Start with an orientation meeting
 - Set social contract and logistics
 - Shared purpose
 - Goals
 - Complete 4 Connects as the first set of processes to test the waters
 - Decide if this FotH is for you at this time



Draft Social Contract

- Scripture as the basis and grounding for everything
 - Also reference “Relational Discipleship”
 - And many others
- Intentionality
 - Desire to grow up into Christ
 - Live out a collective mission
- Regular, scheduled meetings
 - Frequency and times; TBD
 - Location: John’s “Garden Level” or online
- Confidentiality
 - You can share your journey but not another’s

Options for Discussion

- Extending to include others
 - How to do that, in what way
 - Start with us and then offer to the rest of the CCA board
 - Extend later to staff leadership?
 - How about the Trustee board?
 - How about CCA students?
- Open community or not
 - If open, what are the entrance requirements
- Exploration (experimental test bed) for future expansion
 - Measure progress
- Training as a leader of the group
- Occasional weekend retreats for intensives
 - Kickoff session? Logistics?

An Invitation to Join a Community on Your Personal Journey

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